



Money Grows On Trees: Networking 101

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Golden Idea

The most effective way to grow your cold network is via LinkedIn connections. It's the best resource out there to find new people in the industry, and is an extremely powerful tool in your arsenal — here's how to use it effectively.

Importance

What's the main reason this idea is important to understand?

- You only have so many people in your personal network, and while your warm connections are powerful, you will run through them quickly — that's why you need a cold outreach machine, and that's LinkedIn.

“Your network is your net worth.” – Porter Gale

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What is a Network?

In the context of a career, a **network** refers to a group of professional relationships that an individual cultivates over time. These connections can include colleagues, mentors, industry professionals, and others who can provide support, advice, opportunities, or information.

Career networking is about building and nurturing these relationships to advance one's professional goals, enhance skills, and open up job opportunities. A strong network can significantly influence career growth and success, providing access to knowledge, resources, and collaborations.

Think of a network like a forest.



You spend a great deal of time and effort planting connections in your network, and over time, you're able to harvest a massive amount of career capital!



Career capital refers to the valuable skills, experiences, knowledge, and relationships that a person accumulates over time, which make them more valuable and marketable in their profession. That's the resource that people tend to get over time, which makes landing jobs far easier.

So, what are some of these resources and fruits that the network bears?

Referrals

- A referral is when a current employee or someone connected to the company recommends a candidate for a job.
- This **4x's your chance** of being hired. Nuts.
- A referral greatly improves your chances of landing that first interview.

Insider Knowledge

Company Hiring Process

- The person you're talking to has successfully navigated the company hiring process, landed a job there, and has worked there for some time. That means they have a great deal of knowledge about the company, culture, product, and at a minimum, can coach you to fly through the interview process.
- This massively increases your chances of passing that interview.

Tips & Tricks

- The successful individual has most likely picked up tips & tricks that you're not familiar with about the entire job application process — by talking to them, you'll get this Alpha that you can leverage to get ahead of your peers.
- These people have done what you want, so therefore they know things you don't. So learn from them.

Additional Benefits

- **Early Access to Positions** — you could hear about open positions at the company before they get announced to the public, additional opportunities at the company (fellowships, info weeks, etc.), general industry opportunities, positions at other companies.
- **Additional Connections** — software engineers tend to know other software engineers. By talking to people, they might connect you with more people, which makes finding additional connections even easier.
- Overall, networking is so great of a cheat code is remarkable — and barely anyone talks about how to do it well.
- In future modules, I'm going to teach you how to harvest a referral + insider knowledge from your connections. This video is just about how to get started planting that forest and growing your network.



How to Grow Your Network

First of all, you already have a network. Anyone you've talked to & have their contact info — those people are part of your network.

We've already talked about this — these are your warm leads — people you have already been in contact with. And you probably have more than you expect. If you followed the directions in Application Cartography, you should already have a list of people in your network already that you can use for the benefits I mentioned earlier.

The real question is how do you find new people to grow your network, and the secret is going to be to use LinkedIn!

At this point of the program, you should already know how to find companies to apply to, you already have a good resume + LinkedIn, and now you're ready to just turn those cold applications warm through referrals and networking.

Here's what you do, step-by-step.



👉 The LinkedIn Networking Secret Formula

What is a LinkedIn Connection?

LinkedIn connections are professional relationships that you establish on the LinkedIn platform. When you connect with someone on LinkedIn, it means you have mutually agreed to be part of each other's professional network. Connections allow you to see each other's updates, share messages, and potentially leverage each other's networks for job opportunities, business partnerships, or professional advice.

You can directly message these people!

LinkedIn is by-far the best place in the world to grow your cold network because it's a direct line to people in the industry + you can see everyone's background/experience, so you know who to target. It's magical.

Why don't we walk up to people on the street? It's inefficient. You can't see if they have anything to do with the field of software engineering.

Why can't I just contact all the Google engineers? you can't, except you can with LinkedIn. It's wild.

The goal: 500+ high quality connections.

Why 500? Well, when someone hits this number, their account just says 500+. It's a nice round number, an achievable goal in 6 months, and if you hit that, you'll have more than enough people in your network to achieve your goal of landing that job.

It also looks good to people trying to network with you — it's *social proof*! Because you have 500+ people connected with you, future people assume you're someone worth connecting with and are more likely to accept your connection request and talk to you.



👑 What is a High-Quality Connection?

A high quality connection is defined as someone who **is working at or has worked at a company you want to work for**. Nothing more, nothing less.

This is why you **shouldn't just spam connect with people**. See, it's easy to reach 500+ connections if you spam connect to hundreds of people with no filter — well, turns out that completely defeats the purpose of a network.

Only connect with people who have something worth connecting for.

Now, if someone attempts to connect with YOU and is behind you, I'm not saying decline their connection. I'm saying when you outreach, only do it with people worth the effort.

That's the goal — **you'll want to hit 500+ high quality connections in the next 5 months**. That's 100 new connections/month, or around 25/week. So, get to work!



🤫 **The Secret Formula** (ONLY FOLLOW IF LINKEDIN UPDATE IS COMPLETE)

This is the secret formula, step by step, to how to create high quality connections on LinkedIn. Side note — **you'll want to buy LinkedIn premium**, I think it's only a few hundred dollars for the year, but that lets you send out unlimited custom connection requests — and you won't really be able to do that without premium.

You're going to go company by company — based on Application Cartography / Stairway to Software Heaven, you'll know what companies are in your zone of focus. Prioritize those.

1. Find people who are as demographically similar to you as possible at companies you want to work for.

Because of in-group bias, if someone is as close to you demographically as possible, that drastically improves your chances of them accepting a connection request.

Biggest factor — **Alumni or current students at your University.**

This is the greatest tool, and I'll explain why later on. You want to start with people who are at or went to your school — it gives you something to connect about.

Go to the University page, click people, then search the company name.

Now, you'll want to also align on age, ethnicity, gender, etc. Pick people who are college students or new grads, similar ethnicity to you ideally, and similar gender as well.

Obviously, these filters are limiting the people you're connecting with, but it's a good heuristic to utilize in-group bias as much as possible.

The most important are alumni + age, in that order, so start with those. Use the other characteristics if you have an abundance and need to filter down, though that's unlikely. Also, role matters too!

Do your best. If you can't find alumni or young people, then **throw those filters away** and just go with anyone. That's not an excuse to not network.

A lot of people make the mistake of not sending out your messages because you can't find people similar in age, alumni, background — NO. **This is a massive mistake.** This is a starting point and initial filter, but you cannot let that limit your overall efforts.

ex. you want to sort by these filters in this order → company, alumni, age (young), ethnicity, gender, location.

But it's just a sort, so even if you find no one that fits those criteria, you still go for the people you do find.

2. Connect with 10-20 people from a company off the bat

You'll start with 10-20 messages to people at that company, and you'll Scramble & Reattempt if that doesn't get a few connections.

3. Send them a version of this custom message

You'll definitely want to send them a custom message — **DO NOT JUST CONNECTION REQUEST.**

Why? Reciprocity! If someone sees you've put effort into sending a custom message, then they will feel more inclined to actually reply.

Examples:



Navya Ramakrishnan • 2:53 PM

Hi Ella, I wanted to connect as I am a rising junior at Harvard studying computer science and statistics that would love to work at SIG, would love to learn more about you and your experience if you're available - thank you so much!



Sarah Ju (She/Her) • 7:23 PM

Hi Thuy-Vy, I wanted to connect as I am a rising senior at Oregon State studying computer science that would love to work at Oracle someday. I would love to learn more about you and your experience if you're available, thank you so much!



Thuy-Vy Nguyen (She/Her) • 7:24 PM

Hi Sarah!

Thanks for reaching out, sure let me know if you got any questions/ anything I can help with.

Good luck with everything,
ThuyVy



Ella Papanek • 6:45 AM

Happy to chat! What's your schedule like this Tues/wed

TODAY



Guidelines:

1. Include their name
2. Your common school
3. Their company

Now, don't use these exact messages. These are just inspiration — I would recommend modifying it and putting your own spin on them.

If we get hundreds of students in this program sending the exact same message to thousands of people on LinkedIn, it will quickly lose effectiveness — that's why you need to change the wording around.

4. Customize your message

To maximize your chances of getting a reply, you'll want to **customize your message a bit.**

Look at their LinkedIn and add another line in there about something they did — so if they did some volunteering, hackathon, some other job, give a little praise about how you find that super cool and you'd love to learn more about it!

When should you customize or not? It's more important to customize for smaller companies where you have less opportunity. For those, **you must 100% customize each and every message.**

For the large FAANG, it's less important to customize but is still worth your time. You'll also get better at customizing the more you do it.

You have a character limit so you'll need to keep it short.

That's how you do it. You find people who are similar to you at companies you're interested in working for and then send them a custom connection request. It's simple, yet extremely effective.

You'll probably get a 10-20% acceptance rate, based on how similar they are to you and how attractive your profile is. If you're getting less than 10%, then join a coaching call and let me know so we can find out what's going wrong.

Think about that — success means 10-20% reply rate, so you need to pump hundreds of connection requests in here.



In terms of numbers, since you need 25 new connections per week, you'll need to send out at least 100 connection requests per week with custom messages.

Try to keep it under 1 min each and keep a counter. This will take you probably 2h/week, but is well worth it.

With LinkedIn Premium, you get about 100 requests per week — so you might need to be a little strategic with how you use them.

I recommend prioritizing open roles, so if a role is open, then send 20-30 requests to just people from that company alone.

If someone responds, then don't send any more to that company (unless it's urgent).



😞 What Do You Do If They Don't Respond

There's actually a very good chance the person accepts your connection request and doesn't respond. In fairness, you aren't necessarily asking them to respond, **you just want an acceptance.**

If they do this, here's exactly what to do:

You'll have to Fortune is in the Follow-Up them + Mere-Exposure Effect

Basically, **follow up 10+ times.** You'll use the follow-up formula from **Psychic Job Hunting.**

Make sure to exponential backoff — so in this case, after 1 day with no response, follow up, then 3 days, then 5 days, then every week until you hit 10, and then once a month.

Variations Of:

1. "Thanks for accepting my connection request! It means a lot to me..." → then go for the phone call.
2. If they don't respond, use variations of the follow up script. Just keep your tone kind and keep on going.

Pro Tip: On your last message or email, tell them it's your last email — "This is my last email..." so they feel bad



Get Them On A Call

The magical next step is to get them on a 15-min phone call, video chat, or coffee chat. This is the magic bullet. Once they've accepted your request, this is our goal.

Phone calls are where everything happens — those are how you pick the fruit you've planted in your network.



Here's a script to get the phone conversation.

We will discuss how to get a referral on the conversation + how to conduct an informational interview in later modules — what to do on the call, but this is just how to get the convo.

AM

This is if they've replied positively to your initial message OR if they've accepted your connection request & haven't responded.

"Hi [name], thanks so much for connecting! Are you available for a quick 15-min phone (or coffee) chat in the next week? I would love to learn more about your journey from [university] to [company], and it would really help a lot!"

fortune is in the follow up!

If they say they don't have time, then ask them 2 questions directly via Chat.

You can reply with "Totally understandable! Would it be okay if I sent a few questions via chat then?"

Then ask your questions via chat — which will be explained later on.

How do you send your availability if they agree?

"Amazing! I'm really excited to discuss — would any of these times work...."

Phone Call Scripts:

SET UP CALLS AND MEETINGS WITH BUSY PEOPLE

Ramit's feedback

QUICKLY INTRODUCE YOUR REFERRAL -- IF YOU HAVE ONE -- AND YOUR AFFILIATION.

FOR THE PURPOSES OF THIS EMAIL, THE PITCH IS IRRELEVANT. THE POINT OF THIS EMAIL IS COORDINATING THE PHONE CALL, WHICH I OUTLINE IN THE NEXT SECTION.

ALWAYS SPECIFY A SHORT TIME PERIOD. A BUSY PERSON IS LESS LIKELY TO OBJECT TO A MINIMAL TIME COMMITMENT TO A TOTAL STRANGER.

I LIKE 3 CHOICES, AND I TRY TO PROVIDE ONE ALL-DAY OPTION, AS WELL AS TWO NARROWLY DEFINED TIMES. THE "AFTER 1PM" SUGGESTIONS HELP BUSY PEOPLE COPE WITH THE PARADOX OF CHOICE

YOU ARE EXPLICITLY ACKNOWLEDGING THAT THEY ARE HIGHER-STATUS AND POLITELY OFFERING TO HONOR THEIR SCHEDULE. GOOD.

To: Jack Desmond, CEO
From: Jennifer Clark
Subject: Kevin Wu suggested we get in touch -- UC San Diego CS student

Hi Jack,

Kevin Wu recommended I reach out to you. My name is Jennifer Clark and I'm a UC San Diego computer-science student.

I read about your firm's push into clean-tech solutions. At UC-San Diego, we've begun some interesting research here on the topic, and I think there could be a great collaboration.

Do you have time for a 10-minute phone call? If so, would any of these times work?

- * This Wednesday (8/10) all day
- * Thursday (8/11) any time after 1pm PST [IF THEIR TIME ZONE IS PST, YOU PUT YOUR TIMES IN PST]
- * Friday (8/12) any time after 1pm PST

If those don't work, just let me know -- I can work around your schedule.

I can call your office line. Or if you'd prefer, my phone number is (555) 555-5555.

Thanks,

-Jennifer

GIVE THE BUSY PERSON THE OPTION OF WHAT TO DO. SOMETIMES, BUSY PEOPLE WILL JUST CALL YOU RIGHT WHEN THEY RECEIVE THE EMAIL IF THEY HAVE A FEW MINUTES

AM

SET UP CALLS AND MEETINGS WITH BUSY PEOPLE

How to set up a casual meeting and dramatically minimize back and forth emails

TRY TO MAKE IT AN ACTIVE QUESTION, EVEN IF GRAMMATICALLY INCORRECT

USE REFERENCES AND SPECIFICS WHENEVER POSSIBLE

Possible reply:

Hi Ramit,

Sure, I'd love to meet. Let's do Tiramisu Cafe on Park Ave on Thursday at 12:30pm.

Thanks, Michelle

To: Michelle
From: Ramit
Subject: UCSD soph will be in NYC next week -- coffee?

Hi Michelle,

My name is Ramit Sethi and I'm a sophomore at UCSD, where I'm studying technology and psychology. I'll be in New York next week and was wondering -- can I take you to coffee?

Sam Jones and Josephina Young actually suggested I get in touch. I've been working on a persuasive-technology project that might be interesting for your work at Acme Corp.

How does next Thursday, 7/8 or Friday, 7/9 work? I'm free all day, especially the afternoon, and I can meet wherever is convenient for you.

Thanks,

-Ramit
My cell: (555) 555-5555

USING THE WIDE/NARROW TECHNIQUE HERE

Key: Foot in the Door

In this situation, we never go straight for what we want — a referral, interview tips, etc. We go step by step by step which drastically improves your chances of a positive connection.

If we straight up asked for a referral in your initial connection, you're 10x less likely to succeed.

In fact, we don't even ask for a phone call first!

DON'T GET LAZY — go step by step by step. You'll have way more success like this.



In-Person Connections

If you guys are in the same location, then I'd highly recommend meeting in person. You'll put a face to a name and be far more likely to succeed with the referral + information.

You can modify the script to be coffee chat other than just a phone call.

Most Important: Do not give up. You're on the order of hundreds of connection requests, not a few dozen — most people send far too little.

LinkedIn Premium lets you send a lot more custom connection requests, so you need to buy that. Hands down.